

A STRUGGLE FOR THE English Crown

THE WARS OF THE ROSES

From 1455–1485, two rival branches of the Plantagenet dynasty battled for the throne of England. Many noble women participated in the political intrigues and negotiations behind the scenes of a series of battles known as the Wars of the Roses. The warring factions were allied to the descendants of two sons of Edward III: the Dukes of Lancaster and York.

For more than a decade the leader of the Lancastrian faction was Margaret of Anjou, who Shakespeare famously called the “She-Wolf of France.” Margaret married Henry VI of England in 1445, but Henry’s mental instability soon created a power vacuum. She stepped into it; with Henry incapacitated, she fought fearlessly to secure his kingship and the succession of their son, Edward of Westminster. Their cause, however, was dealt a severe blow when Edward died in battle in 1471. Henry was executed, and Margaret was captured and exiled to France.

Peace through marriage

The majority of records from the Wars of the Roses that pertain to women are about noble women and the gentry. During this period,

women’s lives were determined by not only their social status, but by their allegiances, and they succeeded by cultivating relationships with those who were more wealthy and influential. Women were expected to marry in their early 20s and produce children to inherit their husbands’ estates, but as many as 20 percent died in childbirth. During the period of civil war, women also dealt with the vulnerability of a changing political landscape, struggling to keep royal favor as the faction they supported came in and out of power.

Marriages among the nobility at this time were important alliances, formed for ambition rather than for affection. Many of the noble women became embroiled in the wars to secure their legacy, putting their sons and daughters on the throne or in advantageous positions to ensure the family’s continuing success. Elizabeth Woodville (wife of the Yorkist King Edward IV) was widely disliked for her Lancastrian family and nepotism, and remained a dominant force in court politics even after her husband’s death. When the wars finally ended—with the Lancastrian Henry Tudor defeating Richard III in battle in 1485—

Woodville’s influence continued. She secured the marriage of her daughter, Elizabeth of York, to the new king Henry VII in a symbolic union of the two factions. Despite this, however, Woodville and her supporters continued to work against the crown to restore Yorkist control. She even worked alongside her sister-in-law, the Duchess Margaret of Burgundy, to send young pretenders (posing as her dead Yorkist sons) to claim her son-in-law’s throne—with little success.



**“SHE IS KEPT IN
SUBJECTION BY
THE MOTHER
OF THE KING.”**

THE SUB-PRIOR OF SANTA CRUZ ON ELIZABETH OF YORK,
TO FERDINAND AND ISABELLA OF SPAIN, 1498

